Five sources for the bus boycott

Friday 15 January 2027 | P2 | 40 minutes | Year A

Humanities | GROW | Spring 1 Week 2 | HUM-GROW-S1-W02

These five cards are new teaching summaries. The lesson writer made them in 2026. No old text or picture is copied. The record or history behind each card has its own maker and purpose.

S1 A call to stay off buses

Early December 1955 | Campaign leaflet

Jo Ann Robinson and other organisers helped spread a leaflet. It asked Black residents to avoid the buses on Monday 5 December. The first call was for one day. The protest then grew into a much longer boycott.

Maker behind this card: Women’s Political Council members and local leaders.

Purpose: To get people to join a protest.

Ask: Does a call to act prove that everyone joined?

Research basis: H1, H2.

S2 The early demands

About 8 December 1955 | Letter to the bus company

The MIA was the group that led the boycott. Its early demands included polite treatment, seats taken in order of arrival, and Black drivers on mainly Black routes. The seating plan still placed Black riders from the back and White riders from the front. These demands did not yet seek fully mixed seating.

Maker behind this card: MIA leaders, Martin Luther King Jr and U. J. Fields.

Purpose: To ask the bus company to change its rules.

Ask: Does a list of demands prove they were met?

Research basis: H1, H3.

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S3 Keeping the protest going

A later history, updated in 2022, about 1955–1956 | History article

Many people walked or shared car rides so they could stay off buses. Volunteers drove and helped arrange lifts. The MIA raised money to support this work. The campaign needed many people and steady effort, not just one famous leader.

Maker behind this card: US National Park Service.

Purpose: To explain how the boycott worked.

Ask: Can a short history tell us about every journey?

Research basis: H4, H1.

S4 The court ruling

5 June and 13 November 1956 | Court decisions described in a later history

Four Black women challenged bus segregation in the case Browder v. Gayle. On 5 June, federal judges ruled against the segregation laws. On 13 November, the US Supreme Court upheld that ruling. The legal case mattered as well as the boycott.

Maker behind this card: Courts made the rulings; the King Institute wrote the later history.

Purpose: To explain court decisions about bus segregation.

Ask: Does a court ruling tell us how every rider was treated?

Research basis: H5, H4.

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S5 A call to end the boycott

20 December 1956 | Prepared public statement

The court order had reached Montgomery. King announced that the boycott was ending. He asked Black residents to return to buses the next morning with the seating rule removed. His call shows what the leaders wanted people to do next. It does not, by itself, show every bus journey.

Maker behind this card: Martin Luther King Jr for the MIA.

Purpose: To announce the next step after the court order arrived.

Ask: How could we check whether the plan happened?

Research basis: H6.

Our task as source detectives

The new cards are summaries. We have not seen the old records. We can make careful claims using these checked accounts. We cannot judge the old paper, handwriting or picture from a summary.

Ask what a source is useful for. Give a reason and a limit. Check a claim against another source when possible.